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Play Nice

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RAINBOW SKULL

Play Nice
K.R. Schneider

[Dennis and Madeline, a married couple on the brink of divorce, sit in a car. Madeline is frozen, looking out the window in annoyance while Dennis speaks to the audience.]

Dennis: They say you don't really know a person until you live with them. In my case, you don't really know a person until they spend the entire fifth year of marriage trying to hit you in the face with a hairdryer. Or...toaster. Or that one time my flat screen. Madeline's a special kind of crazy. And she hates me. So this marriage is gonna' take the swan dive; that much is clear. Unfortunately, I'm not really up for breaking the news to my parents over family Christmas. Call me spineless, call me whatever you like. More than likely Madeline's already beat you to it. So we've decided to wait until after the holidays and just tell them...via email. Needless to say the four hour car ride has not been the highlight of my holiday season. And smart money says it's just gonna' get worse.

[Dennis sits back to drive – Madeline unfreezes]

Dennis: Listen, Madeline. Can we try to be civil this weekend? It's only two days, and my parents--

Madeline: You understand that I can't stand you, correct?

Dennis: Yeah. I got that. I'm not all that fond of you either if we're being honest.

Madeline: Oh, *you* want to be honest! That's a laugh.

Dennis: Madeline, I just-

Madeline: I hate you, Dennis. Truly. I hate you.

Dennis: I'm not real fond of you either, *Hades*. But we're in this. So when we get to my parents' house we *have to* act like we wouldn't rather be in prison for homicide. No matter how many times I've considered it.

[Madeline freezes – offended – Dennis speaks to the audience].

Dennis: Okay, so I haven't really considered killing her. Well…maybe once. But you can bet she's plotted my gruesome disappearance a time or two!

[Unfreeze]

Madeline: You know what, fine. Whatever! I can play happy family. What I *can't* do is choke down *another* turkey your mother burned.

Dennis: You're kidding. You want to talk about *my mother's* cooking? I think I chipped a tooth

on the last meat-brick *you* made.

Madeline: You said you liked my meatloaf!

Dennis: Yeah. I said I liked your sister too, and we both know that wasn't true.

Madeline: What's wrong with my sister?

Dennis: Nothing. You know…nothing. Some guys like a girl that's been around the block. Or…across the ocean.

Madeline: What is *that* supposed to mean!?

Dennis: Oh, come on, Maddie-

Madeline: DON'T call me that!

Dennis: Your sister is a tramp.

Madeline: She's *finding* herself. And *you* are an insensitive chauvinist.

Dennis: And you're Lucifer, but we all deal with that somehow.

[Madeline pulls back to hit Dennis – She freezes – Dennis addresses the audience].

Dennis: Okay, maybe I deserved that one. But the kind of hole you can dig with the shovel she hands me is just too tempting to resist. I decide maybe it's best to just spend the rest of the trip with my mouth shut. It's actually worked pretty well too. But once we get to my parents house the storm is bound to come crashing through.

[Back to driving – Madeline unfreezes].

Dennis: Well, here we are!

Madeline: Super, you're a GPS now.

Dennis: This is gonna' be a long weekend.

Madeline: I hate you.

Dennis: Really? Because the first 47 times you said that today just didn't seem to drive the nail in.

Madeline: Let's just get this over with.

[They sit in Dennis' parents living room. It's decorated for Christmas. Dennis is appreciating

the decorations. He seems to be in a pretty good mood. Madeline is scowling. She hates it here.]

Madeline: Wow, I forgot how much your mother's silver plastic tree just screams class. You think it was on *sale*?

Dennis: *(defensive)* It's family tradition. It doesn't matter that it's cheap! *(An idea occurs to him)* Just think of it as my family's version of your sister.

Madeline: God, I hate you.

Dennis: Forty-eight. That's forty-eight times since we left.

Madeline: Die.

Dennis: I wish. Can we please just open gifts in silence?

Madeline: Sure, sure. Let's pretend that everything is just peachy.

Dennis: I told you. I'm not ready to tell them!

Madeline: Yeah, because you're totally spineless, "Denny".

Dennis: Stop it! Only my mother calls me that.

Madeline: I think that proves my point.

Dennis: Just open your gift.

Madeline: Wow, Doris! It's beautiful. [reads off of the card] For many years of happy marriage.

Dennis: Of course she did.

Madeline: Just thank her and let's move on.

Dennis: Thanks, Mom. That's great. [opens his own gift] Oh...wow! Look honey, it's a picture frame. And it's….engraved. Look what it says.

Madeline: [reading] Denny and Maddie. Well isn't that...nice.

Dennis: It's great. We'll put it to good use.

Madeline: Smash it. Burn it. Drop it out an upstairs window.

Dennis: Shut up.

[Madeline sits back, satisfied, with her arms across her chest – freezes. Dennis addresses the

audience].

Dennis: So I love my mother okay? Sue me. My wife is demented. If your wife was demented you might call your mother a little more often than normal too. But! Madeline got her digs in – she seems to feel pretty satisfied with herself. I've got to be in the clear here, right?

[Madeline unfreezes, expression automatically angry – punches Dennis in the arm].

Dennis: What the – ouch! What?

Madeline: What. Is. That??

Dennis: What!

Madeline: That *package*! What is the name on that tag?

Dennis: Uh – Chloe?

Madeline: Chloe. Chloe? Chloe! I cannot believe your mother! I thought you hadn't told her!

Dennis: I haven't! What are you talking about?

Madeline: Chloe? *Chloe? (Dennis continues to look at her like she's nuts.)* Chloe is your ex girlfriend. And you know what, I'm sure your mother just *loves* her. I'm sure she even *invited* her.

Dennis: Madeline! I have no idea what you're talking about. I have never dated a Chloe. Never in my life.

Madeline: Are you cheating on me? You're cheating on me!

Dennis: Cheating on you. Yeah. That's what I'm doing, Madeline. I'm cheating on you and I'm telling my *mother* all about it so she can gift wrap sweaters for my *mistress*.

Madeline: I knew it!

Dennis: I imagine that gift is for my *cousin,* Chloe.

Madeline: That's what they all say!

Dennis: I don't-you are insane! When did you *go* insane? What the hell was I doing? How did I miss that?

Madeline: That is *so* hurtful!

Dennis: Are you crying!? Madeline, you've been throwing small appliances at my head for a year! I'm not cheating on you; I just think you're nuts!

Madeline: I am not nuts! I hate you.

Dennis: I think you mentioned that.

Madeline: I mean it, Dennis Arthur Zorowitz. I think you are pond scum. I can't believe I ever married you!

Dennis: Yeah, well don't flatter yourself, Maddie. Like you could've found anyone else to put up with you.

Madeline: How can you say that to me? You are so *hurtful*!

Dennis: You're not exactly a picnic!

Madeline: At least I tell you how I'm feeling. But could you show me the same courtesy? Of course not. You're much too insensitive for that.

Dennis: I am so sick of you telling me what a horrible person I am. I'm the one that asked for a divorce if you'll recall! I think that should pretty much tell you how I feel.

Madeline: You're sending mixed signals.

Dennis: HOW?

Madeline: Never mind. I'm not speaking to you.

Dennis: Promise?

Madeline: See, this is exactly what I'm talking about!

Dennis: I thought you weren't speaking to me.

Madeline: You are a jerk.

Dennis: *[sigh]* I can't wait until this is over.

Madeline: Well at least we agree on something.

Dennis: One thing in five years - quite the record.

Madeline: I hate you.

Dennis: Do you really feel it necessary to mention that every few minutes? Did you think I would forget?

Madeline: You know what - that's it. I can't do this anymore.

Dennis: What are you talking about?

Madeline: You *know* what, “Denny!” Let’s get this over with. Let’s tell your mother!

Dennis: Let’s not make any rash decisions here!

Madeline: Dennis. We. Cannot. Stand. Each other.

Dennis: Yes. Madeline. I realize.

Madeline: I don’t think you do! I’m done pretending. I cannot stand you!

Dennis: And why is that? What did I ever actually do to you?

Madeline: *(takes a deep breath - she’s ready for this)* You snore. You wear socks with your sandals. You drink milk from the carton. You hog the remote. You sweep the floor dirt under the rug. You dust around the pictures and not under them. You have a horrible sense of direction. You fake laugh when nothing is funny. Your favorite tie does not match ANY of your shirts. You eat all but the very last few chips from the bag and don't throw it away.

Dennis: Oh, is that all!?

Madeline: (sighs and looks him over) And if your hairline recedes any further back it’s going to get embarrassing to be seen in public with you.

Dennis: I am not losing my hair!

Madeline: Sure.

Dennis: Fine! Do you want to know what I hate about you?

Madeline: No.

Dennis: Oh. Okay. *(a couple beats of silence and then)*: You bite your fingernails. You eat all of the M&Ms out of the trail mix. You alphabetize *everything*. *(Madeline attempts to speak. Dennis cuts her off.)* No, that's not cute. You chomp your gum. You THROW THINGS AT MY HEAD. You have never been nice to my mother! And you litter.

Madeline: You are SUCH a momma’s boy! If you hate me that much, let’s just TELL her!

Dennis: I don’t want to upset her, Madeline! She has a weak heart. What if she has a heart attack? What if she DIES? It’s CHRISTMAS!

Madeline: I hate you!

Dennis: I know!

Madeline: Dennis. This is ridiculous. I'm telling your mother!

Dennis: Oh no you're not!

Madeline: Oh yes I am!

Dennis: She's gonna' die!

Madeline: She's not gonna' die. Doris! Dennis and I have something to tell you!

Dennis: No we don't!

Madeline: Yes we do. *(Madeline and Dennis turn to a new direction - speak to Doris off stage)* Doris, Dennis and I- *(Doris has a concerning physical reaction off stage.)* Doris!?

Dennis: Mom!? *(They react to Doris' question off stage.) Divorced?* No! Of course we aren't getting divorced!

Madeline: Dennis!

Dennis: She is going to die! *(drags Madeline back to their chairs)* Look Mom! *(gets close to Madeline)* We love each other! No divorce. I promise. We love each other.

[Dennis settles back into his chair, pleased. Madeline crosses her arms, annoyed.]

Madeline: *(defeated)* I hate you.

Dennis: (puts his arm around her) I know. We'll tell 'em at Easter!

[Madeline freezes with his arm around her – Dennis grins and winks at the audience.]